Hongsavatoi in the area around what is today modern day Pegu. Archaeological excavations reveal the use of extensive irrigation systems in the construction of early Mon cities.

A series of Mon kingdoms continued to exert their influence over much of Lower Myanmar for the next 1,000 years until they came under pressure from the Burman and Tai ethnic groups, who began to assert their growing influence. Even though Princess Camadevi of Lopburi founded the northern Mon kingdom of Haripunjaya in the eighth century CE, Mon power began to the decline and came into conflict with the Burman in the ninth century CE when they founded their own empire around the city of Bagan. Under King Anawrahta (r. ca. 1044–1077), the Burman finally defeated the Mon, capturing and transporting 30,000 prisoners including the Mon king Manuha, the royal family, intellectuals, priests, and craftsmen back to Bagan. In the year 1057 CE, the Burman established the kingdom of Bagan, having defeated the Mon. Although the Mon were defeated militarily, their culture, art, alphabet, writing system, and religion, Therāvāda Buddhism, was adopted by Anawrahta. Archaeological evidence points to replacement of Pali and Sanskrit with Mon script in royal documents.

THE ARRIVAL OF THE PYŪ

According to archeologists, the Pyū were the first-known settlers in Upper Myanmar, arriving as far back as 2500 BCE to 2000 BCE. There is archaeological evidence that the Pyū occupied the upper Ayeyarwaddy valley by the first century BCE. Although the origins of the Pyū have been obscured by history, recent archeological evidence suggests that the Pyū were not indigenous to Myanmar but one of the Tibeto-Burmese tribes that migrated via the eastern Himalayas of Tibet, entering Myanmar along the Salween and Nmai Kha valley, eventually settling in the Ayeyarwaddy valley to the north of the Mon. Over the next couple of centuries, the Pyū spread out into the surrounding areas. The distribution of pre-urban Pyū artifacts suggests that eventually the Pyū settled over a large area across Upper Myanmar.

Archaeological evidence suggests that the Pyū cities developed sometime between 400 BCE and 100 CE when the migrating tribes settled along the seasonal tributary streams of Myanmar's dry zone, which in turn, flow into